

MIDLIFE CRISES & MONEY MISMANAGEMENT

Every summer, my wife and I attend a dock party across the lake from our cottage in Muskoka. It's been a regular event for decades. When it started 20 years ago, everybody attending was married. There must have been at least 50 couples, and we all brought our kids. Trevor and Savannah have been going to that party since they were two years old.

But a few years ago, Linda and I began to notice a change. Half the couples were divorced. The men still came to the dock party, but instead of bringing their kids, they brought their new, much younger girlfriends. These guys were spiraling headfirst into midlife crises and they were competing with each other to see who had the most attractive young girl on his arm. The dock party was no longer a celebration of the family dynasty; it was a testament to a lot of broken homes.

Last fall, we were having dinner with some friends in Muskoka when the conversation found its way to the dock party. Our friend Denise, longtime wife of Larry, had had enough of this insanity.

"That's *it*," she declared. "I've been going to this party for the last two decades, but no more. I am 52 years old. I've had three kids. I